

Notes: Ellingsen & Mohlin (JPE, 2026)

A Model of Social Duties

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1 Big picture

- **Question.** Why do people behave selflessly in situations where ordinary altruism, fairness, or material self-interest do not fully explain the behavior?
- **Main contribution.** The paper develops and tests a formal model of social duties. A duty is a moral constraint on actions; violating it creates disutility.
- **Key distinction 1: conditional versus unconditional duties.** Unconditional duties directly label actions as forbidden, permitted, or ideal. Conditional duties depend on consequences and are evaluated using an efficiency/equality social objective.
- **Key distinction 2: strict versus liberal duties.** Strict duties identify minimum acceptable behavior. Liberal duties identify more ambitious or ideal behavior.
- **Utility idea.** The disutility from a duty violation is proportional to the loss that the violation imposes on the other person. The penalty is stronger for strict-duty violations than liberal-duty violations.
- **Why this differs from altruism.** Altruism makes the decision maker value the other person's payoff everywhere. Duties create kinked preferences: once an entitlement is satisfied, the decision maker may stop caring about further transfers.
- **Why this matters.** The model explains several behavioral patterns that are difficult for consequentialist social preferences: returning wallets with more money, giving less when taking options are added to dictator games, and bunching at entitlement-like gifts.
- **Testing strategy 1.** The paper measures duties using appropriateness ratings by spectators. Actions rated inappropriate are interpreted as violating strict duties; actions rated very appropriate identify liberal duties.
- **Testing strategy 2.** The paper structurally estimates the duty model on binary dictator-choice data from Bruhin, Fehr, and Schunk (2019) and compares it with a state-dependent altruism model.
- **Main empirical result.** The duty model fits the data about as well as, and in log likelihood better than, the standard state-dependent altruism model. The estimates imply heterogeneous dutifulness: a strongly dutiful type, a mildly dutiful/selfish type, and a spiteful or competitive type.
- **Takeaway.** Social behavior can be driven by moral duties rather than only by preferences over material allocations. Modeling duties clarifies why context, entitlements, and appropriateness judgments shape economic choices.

2 Conceptual framework and definitions

2.1 Social situations and dictator situations

The paper focuses on simple two-person social situations. A decision maker, called *decider* and indexed by d , chooses an action that affects herself and one passive other person, indexed by o .

- The action set is A , and a typical action is $a \in A$.
- The material consequences are monetary or can be translated into money.
- The consequence function is

$$x : A \rightarrow M \subseteq \mathbb{R}^2,$$

with

$$x(a) = (x_d(a), x_o(a)).$$

- A dictator situation is a four-tuple

$$S = \langle I, A, M, x \rangle,$$

where $I = \{d, o\}$.

Interpretation: The word “dictator” is used broadly. It does not only mean the standard dictator game. It means any situation in which one person chooses and another person is affected.

2.2 Strict duties

A strict duty divides actions into permitted and forbidden actions:

$$A = A_P \cup A_F.$$

- A_P is the set of permitted actions.
- A_F is the set of forbidden actions.
- If decider chooses an action in A_F , she violates a strict duty.
- If only one action is permitted, that action is obligatory, but the model does not require a special category of obligation.

Interpretation: Strict duties are minimum standards. Not stealing, not lying, returning a lost wallet, or performing an easy rescue can all be strict duties in many societies.

2.3 Liberal duties

Among permitted actions, some may be ideal:

$$A_I \subseteq A_P.$$

- A_I is the set of ideal actions.
- If A_I is nonempty and decider chooses a permitted but nonideal action, she violates a liberal duty.
- Permitted nonideal actions are called respectable:

$$A_R = A_P \setminus A_I.$$

Interpretation: Liberal duties are stronger than strict duties. They describe what one ought to do, not merely what one must do. Giving to charity or volunteering can be liberal duties.

2.4 Unconditional duties and entitlements

Unconditional duties classify actions directly, independently of the particular payoff consequences.

- An unconditional strict duty is a function

$$d_S^U : A \rightarrow \{F^U, P^U\}.$$

- An unconditional liberal duty is a function

$$d_L^U : A_P \rightarrow \{I^U, R^U\}.$$

The other person's unconditional strict entitlement is

$$e_S^U = \min_{a \in A_P^U} x_o(a). \quad (1)$$

The other person's unconditional liberal entitlement is

$$e_L^U = \min_{a \in A_I^U} x_o(a). \quad (2)$$

If there is no unconditional liberal duty, the paper defines

$$e_L^U = \min_{a \in A} x_o(a)$$

for completeness.

Interpretation: Entitlements are payoff thresholds implied by duties. If a duty says that certain actions are permitted or ideal, the other person is entitled to at least the smallest payoff generated by such actions.

2.5 Conditional duties and the communal value function

Conditional duties depend on actions' material consequences. The model assumes that the relevant social objective combines efficiency and equality:

$$c(x(a)) = x_d(a) + x_o(a) - \alpha |x_d(a) - x_o(a)|, \quad (3)$$

where $\alpha > 0$ measures the weight on equality relative to efficiency.

The set of conditionally ideal actions is

$$A_I^C = \arg \max_a c(x(a)). \quad (4)$$

The conditional liberal entitlement is

$$e_L^C = \min_{a \in A_I^C} x_o(a). \quad (5)$$

Interpretation: Conditional liberal duties say that the decision maker should pursue the social ideal. In many lab allocation tasks, the ideal combines maximizing total surplus and equalizing payoffs.

2.6 Conditional strict entitlement

The conditional strict entitlement balances the moral ideal against the decision maker's power. Let a^{ego} be the selfish action:

$$a^{ego} = \arg \max_a x_d(a),$$

with payoff to the other x_o^{ego} . The target entitlement is

$$\widehat{e}_S^C = \beta e_L^C + (1 - \beta) x_o^{ego}, \quad (6)$$

where $\beta \in [0, 1]$ is the weight on “right” relative to “might.”

If the exact target is not feasible, the actual strict entitlement is the feasible payoff closest to it, choosing the smaller one if two payoffs are equally close:

$$e_S^C = \min \arg \min_{x_o \in M_o} |x_o - \widehat{e}_S^C|. \quad (7)$$

Interpretation: Strict entitlements are not always equal splits. They depend on what the morally ideal outcome would be and on what the other person would receive if the decision maker behaved selfishly.

2.7 Dutiful preferences

The basic duty utility function is

$$u(a) = x_d(a) - \delta ([e_S - x_o(a)]_+ + \lambda [e_L - x_o(a)]_+), \quad (8)$$

where

$$e_S = \max\{e_S^C, e_S^U\}, \quad (9)$$

$$e_L = \max\{e_L^C, e_L^U\}, \quad (10)$$

and $[z]_+ = \max\{z, 0\}$.

- δ is dutifulness, the overall strength of the moral cost of violating duties.
- $\lambda > 0$ is the relative weight on liberal duty violations compared with strict duty violations.
- e_S combines conditional and unconditional strict entitlements.
- e_L combines conditional and unconditional liberal entitlements.

Interpretation: The decision maker suffers when the other person's payoff falls below an entitlement. The penalty is kinked: once the entitlement is satisfied, there is no further duty-based reward from giving more.

2.8 Generalized preferences with behindness aversion

For estimation, the paper uses a more general specification:

$$u(a) = x_d(a) - \kappa [x_o(a) - x_d(a)]_+ - \delta ([e_S - x_o(a)]_+ + \lambda [e_L - x_o(a)]_+). \quad (11)$$

The parameter κ captures behindness aversion or competitiveness.

Interpretation: Behindness aversion can be selfish competitiveness or an additional moral concern about being behind. The estimates suggest that high dutifulness and positive behindness aversion can coexist.

3 Applications and theoretical predictions

3.1 Application 1: lost wallet experiment

The paper applies the model to Cohn et al.'s lost wallet experiment. A wallet contains money m and a padlock key worth w to the owner. Returning the wallet costs the finder r .

- Action S means report/return the wallet.
- Action N means do not return it.
- Returning gives the decision maker $-r$ and imposes no loss on the owner.
- Not returning gives the decision maker m and costs the owner $w + m$.

The utility comparison implies that the finder returns the wallet if

$$-r > m - \delta(w + m), \quad (12)$$

or equivalently

$$\delta > \frac{r + m}{w + m}. \quad (13)$$

Observation 1. If $r > w$, wallets with more money are more likely to be returned.

Interpretation: When returning the wallet is already a meaningful duty burden, adding money increases the guilt from not returning faster than it increases the gain from keeping the wallet. This explains why wallets containing more money are returned more often.

3.2 Application 2: standard dictator experiment

In a standard \$10 dictator experiment, the dictator chooses gift $g \in [0, 10]$:

$$x_d = 10 - g, \quad x_o = g.$$

The paper argues that there is no unconditional duty in a context-free lab allocation task. The duty is conditional. Since total surplus is fixed, the communal value is maximized at equality:

$$e_L^C = 5.$$

Because the selfish action gives the recipient zero, the strict entitlement is

$$e_S^C = 5\beta. \quad (14)$$

The dictator solves

$$\max_{g \in [0, 10]} 10 - g - \delta([5\beta - g]_+ + \lambda[5 - g]_+). \quad (15)$$

The solution is

$$g = \begin{cases} 0, & \delta < \frac{1}{1 + \lambda}, \\ 5\beta, & \delta \in \left[\frac{1}{1 + \lambda}, \frac{1}{\lambda} \right], \\ 5, & \delta > \frac{1}{\lambda}. \end{cases} \quad (16)$$

Interpretation: The model predicts bunching at zero, at the strict entitlement 5β , and at the equal split. This matches the empirical pattern that many dictators give zero, many give half, and many give intermediate gifts such as 2 or 3.

3.3 Application 3: dictator experiment with taking

List and Bardsley add options that let the dictator take money from the recipient. Let $t > 0$ be the maximum amount the dictator can take. In this case, the selfish payoff for the recipient falls to $-t$, so the conditional strict entitlement becomes

$$e_S^C = (t + 5)\beta - t. \quad (17)$$

However, taking also evokes the unconditional strict duty not to steal. Therefore, if the conditional entitlement would be negative, the unconditional entitlement $e_S^U = 0$ binds.

The paper's solution is

$$g = \begin{cases} -t, & \delta < \frac{1}{1+\lambda}, \\ 0, & \delta \in \left[\frac{1}{1+\lambda}, \frac{1}{\lambda}\right] \text{ and } \beta \leq \frac{t}{t+5}, \\ (t+5)\beta - t, & \delta \in \left[\frac{1}{1+\lambda}, \frac{1}{\lambda}\right] \text{ and } \beta > \frac{t}{t+5}, \\ 5, & \delta > \frac{1}{\lambda}. \end{cases} \quad (18)$$

Interpretation: Introducing a taking option changes the set of feasible actions and the entitlement. Some dictators who previously gave positive gifts now give less, and some who would otherwise take refrain because taking violates the unconditional duty not to steal.

3.4 Why these applications matter

- The lost-wallet application explains a pattern that pure altruism does not predict: more money can increase returns.
- The standard dictator application explains bunching at focal gifts through kinked duty preferences.
- The taking-option dictator application explains violations of contraction consistency: adding options can change the moral interpretation of existing options.

Interpretation: The applications show that behavior depends not only on material allocations but also on how the action set frames duties and entitlements.

4 Testing strategy and empirical implementation

4.1 Survey measurement of duties

The paper measures duties by asking spectators to rate the appropriateness of actions. The instruction is that appropriateness means what the spectator personally considers correct, proper, or ethical.

- Ratings range from very inappropriate to very appropriate.
- Actions rated inappropriate are classified as violating strict duties.
- If an action is rated very appropriate and is not the only appropriate action, lower-rated actions are treated as violating liberal duties.

Interpretation: Spectator judgments provide an independent measure of duties. The paper can then compare predicted duties with behavioral patterns from experiments.

4.2 Survey sample

- The ratings were elicited on Prolific in October and November 2021.
- Subjects were based in the United States.
- The paper used 2,000 subjects, with 150–200 subjects per treatment.
- Subjects received participation payments corresponding to high hourly rates.
- Hypotheses were preregistered before the experiments.

Interpretation: The surveys are not merely informal. The authors design preregistered tests that measure whether appropriateness ratings line up with the duty model’s predictions.

4.3 Appropriateness in the lost wallet experiment

The paper asks whether keeping a lost wallet is rated inappropriate and whether keeping a wallet with more money is rated more inappropriate.

- Keeping the wallet is almost unanimously viewed as inappropriate.
- Most subjects rate keeping as very inappropriate.
- Because of the floor effect, differences between no-money, small-money, and big-money wallets are hard to detect.
- A non-preregistered comparison finds that keeping a no-money wallet is less inappropriate than keeping a big-money wallet.

Interpretation: The survey confirms the core assumption that returning the wallet is a strict duty. It gives weaker but suggestive support for the idea that larger owner losses increase duty-violation disutility.

4.4 Appropriateness in dictator experiments

For the standard dictator experiment, the paper uses appropriateness ratings to infer strict entitlements.

- A spectator’s strict entitlement threshold is the point where gifts move from inappropriate to appropriate.
- Table 3 shows a highly dispersed distribution of strict entitlement thresholds.
- Some spectators think giving zero is acceptable; many others think that giving five is required.

- There is much more agreement about the liberal duty: giving five is usually rated very appropriate.

Interpretation: The dictator game is morally ambiguous. People disagree sharply about the recipient’s strict entitlement, which helps explain why dictator gifts are dispersed.

4.5 Appropriateness with taking options

The paper also studies dictator games where the dictator can take money from the recipient.

- Conditional duties predict that the strict entitlement falls when the dictator gains more power.
- Unconditional duties predict that taking below zero remains morally constrained by the duty not to steal.
- Figure 4 compares appropriateness ratings in the standard dictator setting and take-option settings.

Interpretation: The survey data support both mechanisms: taking options lower perceived conditional entitlements, but outright taking is still constrained by an unconditional duty.

4.6 Structural estimation on Bruhin, Fehr, and Schunk data

The paper uses choice data from Bruhin, Fehr, and Schunk (2019), where subjects choose in 39 binary dictator situations in two sessions separated by three months.

- The situations vary whether helping the other is costly or beneficial to the dictator.
- Some situations put the dictator ahead, some behind, and some cross these states depending on the choice.
- The authors reestimate the Bruhin–Fehr–Schunk state-dependent altruism model on allocation decisions alone.
- They then estimate an analogous three-type mixture model of dutifulness.

Interpretation: This part of the paper asks whether dutiful preferences can fit a rich dataset of binary social choices at least as well as a flexible altruism model.

4.7 Choice error and finite mixtures

Both structural models are estimated as finite mixtures with a logit choice rule.

- The population is assumed to consist of three latent types.
- Each type has its own preference parameters and choice-sensitivity parameter.
- The likelihood sums over types and observed choices.
- The authors use global optimization because the duty model has discontinuities and kinks.

Interpretation: The finite-mixture approach captures heterogeneity. The key question is whether heterogeneous dutifulness can explain choices as well as heterogeneous altruism.

5 Identification and interpretation

5.1 What identifies duties conceptually

- Duties are identified from action classifications, entitlements, and appropriateness ratings.
- Strict duties are identified by actions judged inappropriate.

- Liberal duties are identified by actions judged very appropriate relative to other acceptable actions.
- Conditional duties are identified by how ratings change when consequences or feasible actions change.

Interpretation: The paper separates duties from altruism by focusing on moral thresholds, not only on marginal concern for others.

5.2 What identifies dutifulness behaviorally

- Dutifulness δ is identified by how much material payoff a person is willing to sacrifice to satisfy entitlements.
- The strict-entitlement parameter β is identified by intermediate gifts and by entitlement thresholds.
- The liberal-duty weight λ is identified by movement from strict compliance to ideal behavior.
- Behindness aversion κ is identified by behavior when the dictator is behind the recipient.

Interpretation: The model is not just verbal. It maps choice patterns to separate structural parameters for duty strength, entitlement determination, liberal duties, and competitiveness.

5.3 Limitations

- Appropriateness ratings may differ from the moral pressure felt by actors facing real costs.
- Spectators may rate common behavior as appropriate even if they do not view it as morally required.
- The main model is static and does not model reputation, repeated interaction, or strategic image concerns.
- The model takes duties as given rather than deriving them from evolutionary or institutional foundations.
- Estimation is complex because entitlements can move discontinuously with parameters.

Interpretation: The paper's purpose is proximate explanation: it formalizes how internalized duties shape behavior. It does not claim to provide the ultimate origin of duties.

6 Tables and figures

6.1 Table 1 and Figure 1: classifying duties and the binary dictator situation

Read:

- Table 1 shows the two-by-two classification of duties: strict versus liberal and unconditional versus conditional.
- Examples include not stealing as an unconditional strict duty, easy rescue as a conditional strict duty, optional service charges as unconditional liberal duties, and volunteering for charity as conditional liberal duties.
- Figure 1 presents a binary dictator situation with two actions, H and N .
- The example illustrates how unconditional and conditional duties can generate different strict entitlements.

Economic message: The paper’s core conceptual move is to classify moral obligations by both source and strictness. This generates entitlement thresholds that shape behavior.

TABLE 1 EXAMPLES OF DUTIES		
	Unconditional	Conditional
Strict	Not steal	Perform easy rescue
Liberal	Pay optional service charge	Volunteer for charity

Table 1: examples of duties

H	0,3
N	1,1

FIG. 1.—Binary dictator situation.

Figure 1: binary dictator situation

6.2 Table 2 and Figure 2: lost wallet and dictator utility

Read:

- Table 2 translates the lost-wallet experiment into the duty model.
- Returning the wallet imposes cost r on the finder but avoids the owner’s loss.
- Not returning yields money m to the finder but violates the owner’s strict entitlement by $w + m$.
- Figure 2 illustrates the kinked utility function in the standard dictator experiment.
- The kinks correspond to neglecting duties, satisfying the strict entitlement, and satisfying the liberal entitlement.

Economic message: Duty preferences rationalize why higher owner losses can increase honest behavior and why dictator choices bunch at entitlement-like allocations.

TABLE 2 LOST WALLET EXPERIMENT			
a	x_{db}, x_o	$e_S - x_o$	u
S	$-r, 0$	0	$-r$
N	$m, -(w + m)$	$w + m$	$m - \delta(w + m)$

Table 2: lost wallet experiment

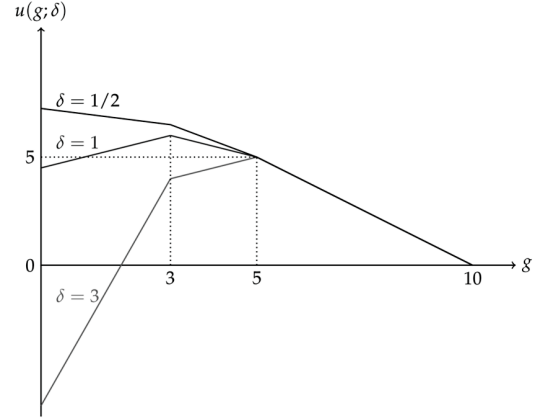


FIG. 2.—Decider's utility in dictator experiment ($\beta = 3/5$, $\lambda = 1/2$).

Figure 2: dictator utility

6.3 Figures 3 and 4 plus Table 3: appropriateness ratings

Read:

- Figure 3 shows that not returning a lost wallet is rated highly inappropriate across treatments.
- Figure 4 shows appropriateness ratings in the standard dictator experiment and in dictator experiments with taking options.
- Table 3 reports strict entitlements implied by spectator ratings in the standard dictator experiment.
- The distribution is dispersed: 24% imply an entitlement of 0, while 32% imply an entitlement of 5.

Economic message: Survey ratings make duties observable. They show strong agreement about lost-wallet duties but sharp disagreement about dictator-game entitlements.

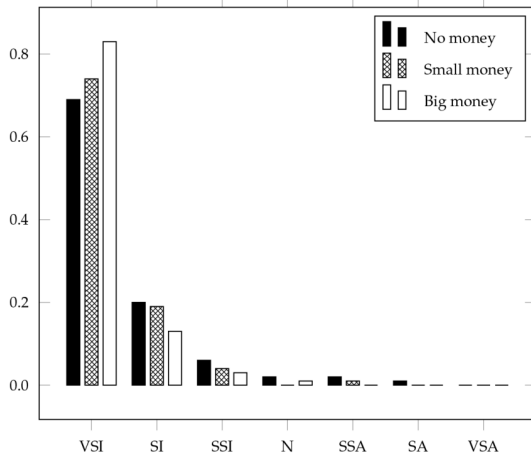


FIG. 3.—Lost wallet experiment: personal appropriateness ratings of not returning, ranging from very socially inappropriate (VSI) to very socially appropriate (VSA).

Figure 3: lost-wallet appropriateness ratings

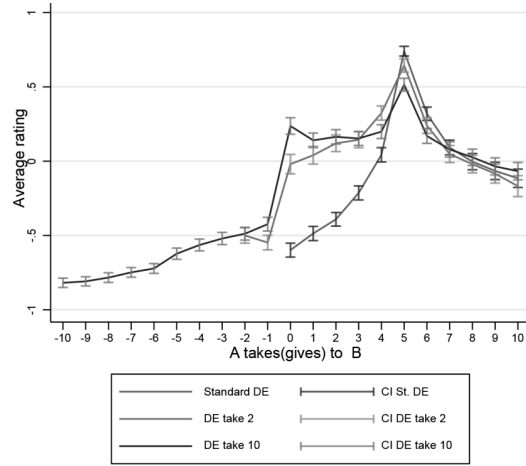


FIG. 4.—Average personal appropriateness ratings in standard dictator experiment and dictator experiment with take options (95% confidence intervals).

Figure 4: dictator appropriateness ratings

TABLE 3
DICTATOR EXPERIMENT: STRICT ENTITLEMENTS IMPLIED BY SPECTATOR RATINGS

	0	1	2	3	4	5
Fraction	.24	.03	.07	.13	.20	.32

6.4 Tables 4 and 5: structural model estimates

Read:

- Table 4 reports the reestimated three-type state-dependent altruism model from Bruhin, Fehr, and Schunk.
- The three types are altruistic, mildly altruistic, and spiteful.
- Table 5 reports the analogous three-type duty model.
- The duty model finds a strongly dutiful type, a mildly dutiful/selfish type, and a spiteful type.
- The duty model has virtually the same accuracy as the altruism model and a better log likelihood, though it uses additional global parameters.

Economic message: Dutifulness can organize a rich set of social choice data about as well as standard altruism, while giving a different interpretation of the underlying motives.

TABLE 4
ESTIMATED THREE-TYPE MODEL OF STATE-DEPENDENT ALTRUISM
(Bruhin, Fehr, and Schunk 2019)

Type	Share	α	β	ξ
A. Session 1 (Log Likelihood = -1,385.7, Accuracy = .926)				
Altruistic	.469	.149	.482	.02
Mildly altruistic	.351	.045	.078	.067
Spiteful	.179	-.387	-.016	.01
B. Session 2 (Log Likelihood = -980.8, Accuracy = .951)				
Altruistic	.449	.159	.469	.023
Mildly altruistic	.449	.042	.072	.085
Spiteful	.102	-.368	-.047	.018

Table 4: state-dependent altruism

TABLE 5
ESTIMATED THREE-TYPE MODEL OF DUTIFULNESS

Type	Share	α	β	λ	δ	κ	ξ
A. Session 1 (Log Likelihood = -1,351.9, Accuracy = .927)							
Altruistic	.487	1.184	.618	.005	1.551	1.105	.009
Mildly altruistic	.325	Same	Same	Same	.134	.080	.064
Spiteful	.189	Same	Same	Same	.049	.458	.012
B. Session 2 (Log Likelihood = -953.3, Accuracy = .954)							
Altruistic	.466	1.183	.654	.000	1.436	1.006	.011
Mildly altruistic	.433	Same	Same	Same	.120	.070	.079
Spiteful	.101	Same	Same	Same	-.140	.364	.011

Table 5: dutifulness model

7 Short summary

- The paper develops a formal model of social duties.
- Duties are strict or liberal and conditional or unconditional.
- Strict duties identify forbidden actions; liberal duties identify ideal actions.
- Conditional duties are based on consequences and combine efficiency with equality.
- Entitlements determine payoff thresholds that the other person is morally entitled to receive.
- The utility function penalizes violations of strict and liberal entitlements.
- The model creates kinked preferences, unlike smooth altruism.
- The lost-wallet application explains why wallets with more money are more likely to be returned.
- The dictator-game application explains bunching at zero, entitlement gifts, and equal splits.
- The taking-option application explains why adding options can reduce giving even among positive givers.
- Spectator appropriateness ratings provide a way to measure duties.
- Lost-wallet nonreturn is almost unanimously rated inappropriate.
- Dictator-game entitlements are highly heterogeneous across spectators.
- Structural estimation shows that a three-type duty model fits binary dictator choices about as well as a state-dependent altruism model.

8 Conclusion

8.1 Core conclusion

Ellingsen and Mohlin provide a formal model of social duties that can explain unselfish behavior not well captured by consequentialist preferences. People may act morally not because they directly value others' payoffs everywhere, but because they experience disutility when they violate duties and entitlements.

8.2 Economic intuition

The model converts moral language into payoff thresholds. Strict duties specify what one must do; liberal duties specify what one ought to do. A person may be willing to sacrifice material payoffs to avoid falling below these thresholds. Once the duty is satisfied, however, there may be little reason to give more. This generates bunching, entitlement sensitivity, and context dependence.

8.3 Takeaway

The paper adds a duty-based foundation to social preference theory. It shows how formal economic modeling can incorporate moral context, appropriateness judgments, and entitlements while still producing sharp predictions and estimable parameters.